

Fig. 12.1: Tissarakshita, Queen of Ashoka

Ashoka’s wives evidently become either good or bad here depending upon whether they supported or thwarted the emperor’s engagement with the Buddha and his faith.[5] At the same time, the powerful voice of his queen in accounts of his later life supplements that of his queen Karuvaki in the epigraphs. The image of the latter there is of a self-possessed and strong-willed consort wanting an act of philanthropy recorded as specifically hers. The king’s later consort as powerful figure—via the story